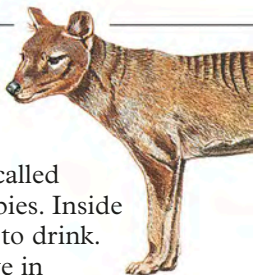




MARSUPIALS



Australia

A marsupial is an animal that has a pocket, called a pouch, on its tummy for carrying its babies. Inside this nursery the baby is safe and has milk to drink. Today, the widest variety of marsupials live in Australia, but 50 million years ago many more lived in the Americas and the Antarctic. Most of the

American ones died out when more

modern mammals, such as horses, cats, and rats, developed. Marsupials survived in Australia because the “new” mammals could not reach this island. Kangaroos are the most famous marsupials, but there are also marsupial “mice” and “dogs.”



Female red kangaroos are three feet (one meter) tall. Males are twice as big. They live in Australia.

Kangaroos can't walk backward!

The tail helps it to balance as it bounds along.

Like deer, kangaroos have long faces to make room for their big, flat, grass-grinding teeth.

Female red kangaroos are called blue fliers because they have blue-gray fur and bounce faster than the red males.

Kangaroos lick a bald spot on their arms to cool down! As the saliva dries it takes heat away.

Only females have pouches—males don't need them because they don't have babies!

The baby, or joey, hops into the pouch if it sees an eagle or dingo.

Huge leg muscles

Jump to it!

A kangaroo's back legs are so big that it would fall over if it ran. But they are good for jumping—a red kangaroo can bounce along at 30 miles (50 kilometers) per hour.